

Craft and Structure

Theory + 24 Worked Questions • 3 Skills

1. Words in Context
2. Text Structure and Purpose
3. Cross-Text Connections

SECTION 1

Words in Context

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Words in Context

10–11 questions per test • 3–7 per module • the most frequent Craft and Structure skill. These are not vocabulary tests — they are context-reading tests. Every answer lives in the surrounding sentence, not in a dictionary.

Why Context Beats Dictionary Knowledge

- The exam deliberately uses ordinary words in unusual ways, and unusual words whose context makes the meaning clear.
- A student who knows every dictionary definition but ignores the sentence will score lower than a student who reads carefully — the test measures reading comprehension, not memorization.
- Your job is to find the meaning the author intends in THIS passage, which may differ from the word's most common definition.

By the numbers — from 60 real Words in Context questions

93% present a fill-in-the-blank format ("Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?"). Only 7% ask you to identify the meaning of a word already in the passage.

100% of real Words in Context questions in the verified bank are rated Hard difficulty — this is consistently the hardest-rated skill category on the exam.

The 5-Step Strategy

- Ignore the answer choices. Read the sentence cold, and predict a simple word of your own — think use, change, build, help, show, reduce, support, hide, limit — before any choice can plant an idea in your head.
- Use the sentence, not the word, to find meaning. Look for cause/effect signals (because, so, therefore), contrast words (however, although, but, yet), definitions or appositive phrases (commas or dashes around explanations), and tone (positive, negative, neutral).
- Replace the word with your prediction. Read the sentence with it inserted — if it sounds natural, that's your anchor.
- Choose the answer closest to your prediction — not the one that sounds most sophisticated.
- Don't fall for dictionary traps. Choices deliberately include the most common meaning (often wrong), a rare/technical meaning (sometimes wrong), and a smart-sounding meaning that doesn't fit (always wrong). Your anchor, not the dictionary, is your guide.

Types of Context Clues

Definition Clue The passage restates or defines the word nearby. Common words: <i>that is, in other words, or, also known as</i>	Contrast Clue An opposite or contrary idea appears near the word. Common words: <i>however, but, although, yet, despite, instead</i>
Cause/Effect Clue The word is explained by its cause or consequence. Common words: <i>because, therefore, as a result, consequently, so</i>	Example Clue Examples near the word reveal its category or meaning. Common words: <i>for instance, such as, including, like</i>

The Tone Test

Before choosing, ask whether the correct answer should be positive, negative, or neutral. Tone eliminates at least one wrong answer almost every time.

Denotation vs. Connotation

Denotation is a word's dictionary definition; connotation is the emotional color it carries. On harder questions, two choices share a denotation but carry different connotations — "slender" vs. "emaciated" both mean thin, but in very different registers. Always match the passage's emotional register, not just the literal meaning.

Common Wrong-Answer Patterns

- Common-meaning trap — the most familiar definition of the tested word is almost always wrong.
- Sound-smart trap — a sophisticated-sounding choice that doesn't fit the sentence logic.
- Partial-fit trap — a word that fits part of the sentence but contradicts the tone or direction.
- Extreme trap — a word that's close but too strong or too weak ("devastated" vs. "disappointed").

Scientific Terms You Must Recognize

Common Wrong-Answer Patterns (cont.)

Term	What It Means	SAT Trap
Sample size	How many subjects were studied? Small = shaky results; large = more reliable.	Confusing "large sample" with "strong proof"
Longitudinal study	Tracks the same subjects over a long time to find trends.	Mixing with cross-sectional (one snapshot)
Model validation	Checking whether a model's predictions match real data.	Assuming a validated model is always correct
Proxy measure	A stand-in measurement for something hard to observe directly.	Treating the proxy as the real variable
Experimental group	The group that receives the treatment or new condition.	Confusing with the control group
Control group	The no-treatment comparison isolates the independent variable.	Thinking "control" means "controlled condition."

Common Wrong-Answer Patterns (cont.)

Term	What It Means	SAT Trap
Confounding variable	An unseen factor that muddles the results.	Ignoring it when evaluating a conclusion
Independent variable	The factor scientists deliberately change.	Swapping with the dependent variable
Dependent variable	The outcome being measured.	Swapping with the independent variable
Correlation	Two variables change together — a pattern, not a cause.	Assuming correlation implies causation
Causation	One variable directly produces a change in another.	Overstating what a study proves
Competing hypotheses	Different explanations scientists compare against evidence.	Treating one hypothesis as proven fact

Common Wrong-Answer Patterns (cont.)

Term	What It Means	SAT Trap
Evolutionary trade-off	A trait that helps in one situation but creates a cost in another.	Seeing evolution as purely beneficial

- The Blank-Word Technique:** When the question asks which word "completes the text," cover the blank and read the whole surrounding sentence. Name the quality the blank must express before looking at the choices.
- Underscore means emphasize:** When the SAT underlines a word, pay extra attention to any contrast or cause-and-effect clue in the same sentence.

Common Wrong-Answer Patterns

WORKED QUESTIONS

Words in Context — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Hard

Some foraging models predict that the distance bees travel when foraging will decline as floral density increases, but biologists Shalene Jha and Claire Kremen showed that bees' behavior is inconsistent with this prediction if flowers in dense patches are _____. bees will forage beyond patches of low species richness to acquire multiple resource types.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A. depleted

B. homogeneous

C. immature

D. dispersed

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is B.
- It most logically completes the text’s discussion of Jha and Kremen’s finding about bees’ foraging behavior.
- In this context, “homogeneous” means uniform or of the same kind.
- The text indicates that some models predict that the distance that bees travel when they’re foraging declines as the density of flowers increases.
- The text goes on to say, however, that Jha and Kremen identified a circumstance in which bees don’t behave this way.
- Specifically, if bees encounter “patches of low species richness”—that is, patches in which the flowers are largely from the same species—they’ll travel beyond those patches to get varied food resources.
- This context thus suggests that bees don’t behave as some models predict if the dense patches of flowers the bees encounter are homogeneous.

Tip

Predict your own word from context before looking at the choices — the most familiar dictionary meaning of the tested word is often the trap, not the answer.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: the text indicates that Jha and Kremen found that bees will behave differently than some models predict if the bees encounter flower patches that are not rich in species, not if the flowers are “depleted,” or emptied or reduced in quality or quantity. Although it could be true that bees are likely to leave depleted patches in search of more resources, the text doesn’t indicate that Jha and Kremen investigated that possibility.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	depleted	Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that Jha and Kremen found that bees will behave differently than some models predict if the bees encounter flower patches that are not rich in species, not if the flowers are “depleted,” or emptied or reduced in quality or quantity. Although it could be true that bees are likely to leave depleted patches in search of more resources, the text doesn’t indicate that Jha and Kremen investigated that possibility.
✓ B	homogeneous	Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Jha and Kremen’s finding about bees’ foraging behavior. In this context, “homogeneous” means uniform or of the same kind. The text indicates that some models predict that the distance that bees travel when they’re foraging declines as the density of flowers increases. The text goes on to say, however, that Jha and Kremen identified a circumstance in which bees don’t behave this way. Specifically, if bees encounter “patches of low species richness”—that is, patches in which the flowers are largely from the same species—they’ll travel beyond those patches to get varied food resources. This context thus suggests that bees don’t behave as some models predict if the dense patches of flowers the bees encounter are homogeneous.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination (cont.)

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X C	immature	Choice C is incorrect because there’s no information in the text suggesting that bees will not behave as some models predict if flowers in patches are “immature,” or not fully developed. Instead, the text indicates that Jha and Kremen found that bees will behave contrary to some models’ predictions if the flower patches are not rich in species.
X D	dispersed	Choice D is incorrect because the text indicates that bees’ behavior will be inconsistent with the predictions of some models if the flower patches that the bees encounter are of low species richness, not if the flowers are in patches that are “dispersed,” or widely scattered. Although the text does describe bees as leaving patches that are not rich in species to forage elsewhere, there’s no suggestion that Jha and Kremen found that the distance between dense flower patches affects whether the bees behave as some models predict.

Question 2

Hard

In 2016, Gabriela González and team announced that a chirping sound captured by Laser Interferometer Gravitational-Wave Observatory antennas was direct evidence of gravitational waves, which skeptics had argued would be too faint for detection. Detailed statistical analysis helped preclude claims of the event's _____, confirming the signal at a confidence level of over 99%.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A.** inconspicuousness
- B.** discretion
- C.** ambiguity
- D.** probability

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is C.
- It most logically completes the text's discussion of Gabriela González and team's detection of gravitational waves.
- In this context, "ambiguity" means uncertainty or doubtfulness.
- The text explains that although skeptics had thought that direct evidence of gravitational waves would be too faint to be detected, researchers led by González claimed that a chirping sound captured by Laser Interferometer Gravitational-Wave Observatory antennas nevertheless provided such evidence.
- The text goes on to say that detailed statistical analysis confirmed the observation of gravitational waves with a high degree of confidence—that is, with near certainty—a finding that helped to preclude, or rule out, any claims that the signal's attribution to gravitational waves might be ambiguous or doubtful.

Question 2 — Rule, Tip & Trap

Tip

Predict your own word from context before looking at the choices — the most familiar dictionary meaning of the tested word is often the trap, not the answer.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: In this context, "inconspicuousness" would mean the quality of being unnoticeable or difficult to detect. Although the text indicates that skeptics had doubted whether gravitational waves could be observed directly because of their presumed faintness (which suggests that gravitational waves were expected to be difficult to detect), the blank portion of the text isn't referring to the possibility that gravitational waves are unnoticeable or undetectable. Instead, the focus of the last sentence is González's team's observation of a chirping sound that they attributed to gravitational waves, and it wouldn't make sense to say that through statistical analysis, they ruled out the possibility that the sound they observed was undetectable. Rather, the skeptical view presented in the text suggests that there could be some ambiguity about the source of the chirping, but statistical analysis virtually eliminated this uncertainty.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	inconspicuousness	Choice A is incorrect. In this context, "inconspicuousness" would mean the quality of being unnoticeable or difficult to detect. Although the text indicates that skeptics had doubted whether gravitational waves could be observed directly because of their presumed faintness (which suggests that gravitational waves were expected to be difficult to detect), the blank portion of the text isn't referring to the possibility that gravitational waves are unnoticeable or undetectable. Instead, the focus of the last sentence is González's team's observation of a chirping sound that they attributed to gravitational waves, and it wouldn't make sense to say that through statistical analysis, they ruled out the possibility that the sound they observed was undetectable. Rather, the skeptical view presented in the text suggests that there could be some ambiguity about the source of the chirping, but statistical analysis virtually eliminated this uncertainty.
X B	discretion	Choice B is incorrect because in this context, "discretion" would mean good judgment, and it wouldn't make sense to say that an event, such as the detection of gravitational waves, would show judgment, much less that the event's capacity to exercise good judgment would be precluded by statistical analysis confirming its attribution.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination (cont.)

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ C	ambiguity	Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Gabriela González and team’s detection of gravitational waves. In this context, "ambiguity" means uncertainty or doubtfulness. The text explains that although skeptics had thought that direct evidence of gravitational waves would be too faint to be detected, researchers led by González claimed that a chirping sound captured by Laser Interferometer Gravitational-Wave Observatory antennas nevertheless provided such evidence. The text goes on to say that detailed statistical analysis confirmed the observation of gravitational waves with a high degree of confidence—that is, with near certainty—a finding that helped to preclude, or rule out, any claims that the signal’s attribution to gravitational waves might be ambiguous or doubtful.
X D	probability	Choice D is incorrect because in this context, "probability" would mean likelihood, and the text states that statistical analysis, which confirmed the signal with a high degree of confidence, suggests the likelihood that the chirping sound was produced by gravitational waves, not that the analysis helped to preclude this likelihood.

Question 3

Hard

The güiro, a musical instrument traditionally made from a dried and hollowed gourd, is thought to have originated with the Taíno people of Puerto Rico. Players use a wooden stick to scrape along ridges cut into the side of the gourd, creating sounds that are highly _____. The sounds produced by güiros can differ based on the distance between the ridges, the types of strokes the player uses, and the thickness of the gourd.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A. overlooked

B. powerful

C. routine

D. variable

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is D.
- It most logically completes the text’s discussion of the sounds made by güiros.
- In this context, “variable” means able to change.
- The text begins by explaining that güiros are instruments made out of hollowed gourds with ridges cut into their sides and that players scrape the ridges with wooden sticks to produce sounds.
- The text goes on to say that güiros’ sounds can change depending on gourd thickness, the distance between ridges, and the types of strokes the player uses, thus supporting the idea that the sounds created by these instruments are variable.

Tip

Predict your own word from context before looking at the choices — the most familiar dictionary meaning of the tested word is often the trap, not the answer.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: “overlooked” means not being seen or noticed, and there is nothing in the text to suggest that the sounds produced by güiros are overlooked or not noticed.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **D**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	overlooked	Choice A is incorrect because “overlooked” means not being seen or noticed, and there is nothing in the text to suggest that the sounds produced by güiros are overlooked or not noticed.
X B	powerful	Choice B is incorrect because in this context, “powerful” would mean having a great ability to produce an effect. While it’s possible that the sounds produced by güiros have a strong effect on listeners, the text doesn’t discuss this aspect of their sounds.
X C	routine	Choice C is incorrect because “routine” means usual and unvarying, and there is nothing in the text to suggest that the sounds produced by güiros are unvarying. In fact, the text describes how the sounds produced by güiros can differ based on several factors.
✓ D	variable	Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the sounds made by güiros. In this context, “variable” means able to change. The text begins by explaining that güiros are instruments made out of hollowed gourds with ridges cut into their sides and that players scrape the ridges with wooden sticks to produce sounds. The text goes on to say that güiros’ sounds can change depending on gourd thickness, the distance between ridges, and the types of strokes the player uses, thus supporting the idea that the sounds created by these instruments are variable.

Question 4

Hard

Before the Mariner 2 mission completed a successful flyby of Venus in 1962, astronomers' ideas about the planet were little more than _____. Venus's atmosphere is so thick that Earth-based observations had yielded very little information about the planet.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A.** summations
- B.** conjectures
- C.** conclusions
- D.** exemplifications

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is B.
- It most logically completes the text’s discussion of pre-Mariner 2 ideas about Venus.
- In this context, “conjectures” means guesses or inferences formed without sufficient evidence.
- The text indicates that before the successful 1962 flyby, Earth- based observations of Venus had produced “very little information” because of the planet’s thick atmosphere.
- The limited scope of astronomers’ earlier knowledge of Venus is also emphasized by the text’s description of their ideas as being “little more than” something before the flyby.
- This context conveys that before Mariner 2 flew close to Venus, astronomers lacked the evidence needed for their ideas about the planet to be much more than conjectures, or guesses.

Tip

Predict your own word from context before looking at the choices — the most familiar dictionary meaning of the tested word is often the trap, not the answer.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: In this context, “summations” would be final conclusions reached by putting all information together. Because the text emphasizes that very little information about Venus was available before the 1962 flyby, it wouldn’t make sense to describe astronomers’ pre- Mariner 2 ideas about Venus as summations; the text suggests that astronomers didn’t have enough information to draw solid conclusions about Venus.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	summations	Choice A is incorrect. In this context, “summations” would be final conclusions reached by putting all information together. Because the text emphasizes that very little information about Venus was available before the 1962 flyby, it wouldn’t make sense to describe astronomers’ pre-Mariner 2 ideas about Venus as summations; the text suggests that astronomers didn’t have enough information to draw solid conclusions about Venus.
✓ B	conjectures	Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of pre-Mariner 2 ideas about Venus. In this context, “conjectures” means guesses or inferences formed without sufficient evidence. The text indicates that before the successful 1962 flyby, Earth- based observations of Venus had produced “very little information” because of the planet’s thick atmosphere. The limited scope of astronomers’ earlier knowledge of Venus is also emphasized by the text’s description of their ideas as being “little more than” something before the flyby. This context conveys that before Mariner 2 flew close to Venus, astronomers lacked the evidence needed for their ideas about the planet to be much more than conjectures, or guesses.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination (cont.)

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X C	conclusions	Choice C is incorrect. In this context, “conclusions” would be reasoned final judgments or outcomes. Because the text emphasizes that very little information about Venus was available before the 1962 flyby, it wouldn’t make sense to describe astronomers’ pre-Mariner 2 ideas about Venus as conclusions; the text suggests that astronomers didn’t have what they would have needed to make informed judgments about Venus.
X D	exemplifications	Choice D is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to describe astronomers’ pre-Mariner 2 ideas about Venus as “exemplifications,” or examples that illustrate something; people’s ideas about a subject are the ideas themselves, not illustrations. Further, the text emphasizes that the astronomers had little information before 1962, suggesting they didn’t have much to work with to form examples.

Question 5

Hard

Proposals to raise the age at which retirees begin receiving government transfers of funds are generally discussed in terms of the effects on transfer recipients, but Andria Smythe has argued that delaying such transfers could _____ wealth creation among working adults by lengthening the period in which they are providing financial support to their nonworking parents.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A. stymie

B. compound

C. disparage

D. outstrip

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is A.
- It most logically completes the text's discussion of the consequences of raising the age at which retirees begin receiving government funds.
- The text indicates that raising the age for these funds is usually discussed in terms of effects on fund recipients but that Andria Smythe is instead considering the effects on working family members who care for retirees.
- Smythe notes that raising the age for the funds would increase the length of time retirees are dependent on financial assistance from working family members.
- This is suggested to have an effect on wealth creation for those workers, and most logically, that effect would be disadvantageous.
- Thus, "stymie," which means to prevent or greatly hinder, is the most logical choice in context.

Tip

Predict your own word from context before looking at the choices — the most familiar dictionary meaning of the tested word is often the trap, not the answer.

Trap

Choice B is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: in this context, "compound" would most nearly mean multiply or greatly enhance. The text indicates that raising the age at which retirees are eligible for government funds will increase the amount of time retirees are dependent on working family members for financial support. This would likely have a negative rather than a positive effect on wealth creation.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	stymie	Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text's discussion of the consequences of raising the age at which retirees begin receiving government funds. The text indicates that raising the age for these funds is usually discussed in terms of effects on fund recipients but that Andria Smythe is instead considering the effects on working family members who care for retirees. Smythe notes that raising the age for the funds would increase the length of time retirees are dependent on financial assistance from working family members. This is suggested to have an effect on wealth creation for those workers, and most logically, that effect would be disadvantageous. Thus, "stymie," which means to prevent or greatly hinder, is the most logical choice in context.
✗ B	compound	Choice B is incorrect because in this context, "compound" would most nearly mean multiply or greatly enhance. The text indicates that raising the age at which retirees are eligible for government funds will increase the amount of time retirees are dependent on working family members for financial support. This would likely have a negative rather than a positive effect on wealth creation.
✗ C	disparage	Choice C is incorrect because in this context, "disparage" would most nearly mean criticize or defame. Nothing in the text suggests that raising the age at which retirees are eligible for government funds would defame wealth creation among working adults.
✗ D	outstrip	Choice D is incorrect because in this context, "outstrip" would most nearly mean to exceed, and nothing in the text indicates that the financial support provided to retirees would exceed the amount of wealth these workers can create. The text does suggest that workers providing funds to retirees works against those workers' wealth accumulation, but not that the support to retirees exceeds the workers' accumulated wealth.

Question 6

Hard

Among saltwater fish species, there is a clear association between habitat latitude and morphological variety. While tropical species are _____ deep-bodied physical forms (body shapes that are laterally compressed but vertically extended), polar and temperate species are highly dispersed across the morphological spectrum.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A.** authenticated by
- B.** habituated to

- C.** contemporary with
- D.** concentrated among

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is D.
- It most logically completes the text’s discussion of the relationship between habitat latitude and body shape in saltwater fish species.
- In this context, “concentrated among” means largely confined to.
- The text sets up a contrast between tropical species, which are generally characterized by a single shape—deep-bodied forms—and polar and temperate species, which are “highly dispersed across the morphological spectrum” (meaning they exhibit a wide range of body shapes).
- This context supports the idea that tropical species are concentrated among deep-bodied physical forms—that is, largely confined to this single morphological category rather than spread across many.

Tip

Predict your own word from context before looking at the choices — the most familiar dictionary meaning of the tested word is often the trap, not the answer.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: saying that tropical species are “authenticated by,” or proven genuine by, deep-bodied physical forms wouldn’t make sense. Instead, the text describes the typical morphology (body shape) of tropical fish species and how that differs from the typical morphologies of polar and temperate fish species.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **D**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	authenticated by	Choice A is incorrect because saying that tropical species are “authenticated by,” or proven genuine by, deep-bodied physical forms wouldn’t make sense. Instead, the text describes the typical morphology (body shape) of tropical fish species and how that differs from the typical morphologies of polar and temperate fish species.
X B	habituated to	Choice B is incorrect because saying that tropical species are “habituated to,” or accustomed through repeated exposure to, deep-bodied physical forms wouldn’t make sense. Instead, the text describes the typical morphology (body shape) of tropical fish species and how that differs from the typical morphologies of polar and temperate fish species.
X C	contemporary with	Choice C is incorrect because saying that tropical species are “contemporary with,” or existing at the same time as, deep-bodied physical forms indicates that the species exist at the same time as their body shapes do, which, if it is a meaningful statement at all, is at best trivially true and unrelated to the text’s discussion of the typical morphology (body shape) of tropical fish species and how that differs from the typical morphologies of polar and temperate fish species.
✓ D	concentrated among	Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the relationship between habitat latitude and body shape in saltwater fish species. In this context, “concentrated among” means largely confined to. The text sets up a contrast between tropical species, which are generally characterized by a single shape—deep-bodied forms—and polar and temperate species, which are “highly dispersed across the morphological spectrum” (meaning they exhibit a wide range of body shapes). This context supports the idea that tropical species are concentrated among deep-bodied physical forms—that is, largely confined to this single morphological category rather than spread across many.

Question 7

Hard

The following text is adapted from Edith Wharton’s 1911 novella *Ethan Frome*. The narrator has asked the woman he rents a room from about Ethan Frome, a town resident he encountered recently. Her mind was a store-house of innocuous anecdote and any question about her acquaintances brought forth a volume of detail; but on the subject of Ethan Frome I found her unexpectedly reticent. There was no hint of disapproval in her reserve; I merely felt in her an insurmountable reluctance to speak of him.

As used in the text, what does the word “reserve” most nearly mean?

- A.** Modesty
- B.** Misgiving
- C.** Constraint
- D.** Composure

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is C.
- As used in the text, “reserve” most nearly means constraint, or repression of one’s behavior or actions.
- The text indicates that although the narrator’s landlady is ordinarily “a store-house of innocuous anecdote” who readily produces “a volume of detail” in response to questions about her acquaintances—that is, she usually tells harmless stories and is willing to share details about people she knows—she is “unexpectedly reticent,” or surprisingly unwilling to speak, when it comes to Ethan Frome.
- The narrator then observes that the landlady doesn’t appear to disapprove of Ethan, she simply seems completely reluctant to speak of him.
- In this context, then, “reserve” refers to the landlady’s constraint—her repression of her usual willingness to share details in conversation.

Tip

Predict your own word from context before looking at the choices — the most familiar dictionary meaning of the tested word is often the trap, not the answer.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: “Modesty” can refer to being appropriate in speech or behavior, and one might consider it appropriate to decline to speak of someone, but the text gives no indication that the narrator thinks the landlady is acting out of modesty. The narrator suggests that the landlady generally isn’t concerned about the appropriateness of discussing others (she’s usually “a store-house of innocuous anecdote” and shares many details) and isn’t holding back to avoid saying something negative about Ethan Frome (there’s “no hint of disapproval”); indeed, the narrator suggests he can’t tell why the landlady is so unwilling to speak of Ethan.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	Modesty	Choice A is incorrect. “Modesty” can refer to being appropriate in speech or behavior, and one might consider it appropriate to decline to speak of someone, but the text gives no indication that the narrator thinks the landlady is acting out of modesty. The narrator suggests that the landlady generally isn’t concerned about the appropriateness of discussing others (she’s usually “a store-house of innocuous anecdote” and shares many details) and isn’t holding back to avoid saying something negative about Ethan Frome (there’s “no hint of disapproval”); indeed, the narrator suggests he can’t tell why the landlady is so unwilling to speak of Ethan.
X B	Misgiving	Choice B is incorrect because the text never suggests that the landlady has any “misgiving,” or feeling of doubt or apprehension, about Ethan Frome. In fact, the text explicitly states that there is “no hint of disapproval” in her surprising unwillingness to discuss Ethan.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination (cont.)

Correct answer: **C**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ C	Constraint	Choice C is the best answer because as used in the text, “reserve” most nearly means constraint, or repression of one’s behavior or actions. The text indicates that although the narrator’s landlady is ordinarily “a store-house of innocuous anecdote” who readily produces “a volume of detail” in response to questions about her acquaintances—that is, she usually tells harmless stories and is willing to share details about people she knows—she is “unexpectedly reticent,” or surprisingly unwilling to speak, when it comes to Ethan Frome. The narrator then observes that the landlady doesn’t appear to disapprove of Ethan, she simply seems completely reluctant to speak of him. In this context, then, “reserve” refers to the landlady’s constraint—her repression of her usual willingness to share details in conversation.
✗ D	Composure	Choice D is incorrect because the narrator doesn’t suggest that the landlady is acting with “composure,” or calmness and control of her emotions. Instead of describing the landlady’s emotional state or presenting her as calm, the narrator simply conveys her surprising unwillingness to discuss Ethan Frome.

Question 8

Hard

Seminole/Muscogee director Sterlin Harjo _____ television’s tendency to situate Native characters in the distant past: this rejection is evident in his series *Reservation Dogs*, which revolves around teenagers who dress in contemporary styles and whose dialogue is laced with current slang.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A. repudiates

B. proclaims

C. foretells

D. recants

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is A.
- It most logically completes the text’s discussion of Sterlin Harjo’s approach to representing Native characters on television.
- As used in this context, “repudiates” means rejects or refuses to have anything to do with.
- The text indicates that television shows tend to depict Native characters as living long ago, but that Harjo’s series *Reservation Dogs* focuses on Native teenagers in the present day, representing a “rejection” of the typical approach to depicting Native characters.
- This context thus indicates that Harjo repudiates television’s general tendency regarding Native characters.

Tip

Predict your own word from context before looking at the choices — the most familiar dictionary meaning of the tested word is often the trap, not the answer.

Trap

Choice B is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: the text describes Harjo’s “rejection” of the typical approach to representing Native characters on television, so it wouldn’t make sense to say that Harjo “proclaims,” or declares or affirms, television’s general tendency regarding Native characters. Harjo is described as refusing to follow the pattern of depicting Native characters in the distant past, not as proclaiming that pattern.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	repudiates	Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Sterlin Harjo’s approach to representing Native characters on television. As used in this context, “repudiates” means rejects or refuses to have anything to do with. The text indicates that television shows tend to depict Native characters as living long ago, but that Harjo’s series Reservation Dogs focuses on Native teenagers in the present day, representing a “rejection” of the typical approach to depicting Native characters. This context thus indicates that Harjo repudiates television’s general tendency regarding Native characters.
✗ B	proclaims	Choice B is incorrect because the text describes Harjo’s “rejection” of the typical approach to representing Native characters on television, so it wouldn’t make sense to say that Harjo “proclaims,” or declares or affirms, television’s general tendency regarding Native characters. Harjo is described as refusing to follow the pattern of depicting Native characters in the distant past, not as proclaiming that pattern.
✗ C	foretells	Choice C is incorrect because the text describes television’s tendency to represent Native characters in the distant past as something that is already occurring, not as something that Harjo “foretells,” or predicts will happen in the future. The text is focused on Harjo’s “rejection” of this pattern, not on any predictions he may have about it.
✗ D	recants	Choice D is incorrect because saying that Harjo “recants” something would mean that he withdraws a previously held belief, and it wouldn’t make sense to say that Harjo recants television’s tendency to represent Native characters as living in the past. No beliefs previously held by Harjo are mentioned. Additionally, a tendency isn’t a belief and thus isn’t something that can be recanted.

Quick Review — Words in Context

At a Glance

Tests context-reading, not vocabulary. Your #1 move: predict your own word before looking at choices.

Common words: *10–11 questions/test*

Top Rules — Never Forget

- Predict before you look at choices.
- "However / but / yet / although" = opposite meaning.
- Colons and dashes introduce definitions.
- Tone eliminates at least one wrong answer every time.
- The most common meaning is almost always wrong.

SECTION 2

Text Structure and Purpose

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Text Structure and Purpose

Up to 4 questions per test • 1–3 in Module 1, 0–2 in Module 2 • these questions reward readers who think like authors. The exam asks not what the passage says, but why it was built the way it was.

What the question looks like

"Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?"

"Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?"

"Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?"

The Core Insight

- Every sentence in a well-written passage is doing a specific job — the author didn't include it by accident.
- The most important shift you can make is from asking "What does this say?" to asking "What is this DOING?"
- Authors make choices — what to put first, what evidence to include, when to introduce a counterargument, how to end. Answering these questions means reverse-engineering those choices.

By the numbers — from 45 real Text Structure and Purpose questions

"Function" framing ("which choice best describes the function of...") appears in 56% of questions — more common than "main purpose" framing (31%). The rest use other framings (structure, overall organization).

96% of real Text Structure and Purpose questions are rated Hard — alongside Words in Context, this is one of the two hardest-rated skill categories on the exam.

Strategy: The 8-Point System

- Identify the "job" of the sentence or paragraph — introducing, providing evidence, explaining, countering, concluding, or shifting tone.
- Look for structural clues: cause/effect (because, therefore), contrast (however, although), addition (moreover, furthermore), examples (for instance), conclusion (thus, in summary).
- Focus on why the author included the detail — ask "if this sentence disappeared, what would the passage lose?"
- Match the answer to the big picture — a common trap is a choice that's true but irrelevant to the passage's overall goal.
- Beware of micro-reading — distractors that focus too narrowly on one phrase. Purpose questions require macro-reading.
- Use the function test: try "The author includes this part in order to..." — if the sentence becomes awkward or illogical, eliminate that choice.
- Watch for common wrong-answer patterns. The SAT often includes: purposes that are too extreme • purposes that contradict the author's tone • purposes that introduce ideas not in the passage • purposes that misrepresent the author's stance. If an answer feels like a stretch, it probably is.

Strategy: The 8-Point System (cont.)

- Watch for purposes that are too extreme, contradict the author's tone, introduce ideas not in the passage, or misrepresent the author's stance.
- Practice on any short passage: what is the author doing here, and why did they structure it this way?

The Rhetorical Function Vocabulary

Introduce Present a topic, claim, or character for the first time. Common words: <i>first sentences, opening paragraphs</i>	Establish Set up context, tone, or a position. Common words: <i>opening sentences, background info</i>
Support / Illustrate Provide evidence or an example for a claim. Common words: <i>"for instance," statistics</i>	Complicate / Qualify Add nuance or a limitation to a claim already made. Common words: <i>"however," "but," "yet"</i>
Challenge / Counter Introduce an opposing view or refute a claim. Common words: <i>contrasting sentences, counterarguments</i>	Concede Acknowledge the validity of an opposing view. Common words: <i>"admittedly," "granted," "to be fair"</i>
Conclude / Summarize Bring the argument to a close or restate the main idea. Common words: <i>final sentences ending with "thus"</i>	Transition Move from one idea to another. Common words: <i>sentences linking two paragraphs or ideas</i>

The Rhetorical Function Vocabulary (cont.)

Emphasise

Highlight the importance of a point already made

Repetition, exclamatory phrases

Structural Patterns the Exam Loves

- Claim → Evidence → Conclusion — most common: main idea first, examples in the middle, summary at the end.
- Problem → Solution — a challenge is described, then an approach or answer is offered.
- Observation → Explanation — a phenomenon is described, then a cause or mechanism is proposed.
- Claim → Counterargument → Rebuttal — a claim is made, an objection acknowledged, then defended.
- Chronological — events or discoveries described in time order.
- Comparison — two things, approaches, or ideas set side by side.

The Disappearance Test

For underlined-sentence or specific-detail questions, mentally delete the sentence and ask what the passage loses. The correct answer names exactly what disappears — a transition, a concrete example, a qualification, a counterpoint.

The Verb Test

Read the first word of each answer choice and decide what verb your answer needs before reading the full choice. Eliminate every option that starts with the wrong verb before evaluating the rest of the sentence.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Text Structure and Purpose — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Hard

Dubautia carrii is a species in a family of plants known collectively as the silversword alliance, all of which grow only on the Hawaiian Islands. Members of this alliance exhibit an extraordinary range of phenotypes, with some species maturing into vines and others into shrubs and trees. All species in the alliance descended from a single ancestral tarweed plant that arrived on the islands around 5 million years ago. The tarweed's descendants diversified into distinct species as they adapted to live in the wide variety of habitats found on the Hawaiian Islands.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A.** To indicate the specific tarweed ancestor of all plants that grow on the Hawaiian Islands and explain why the plants have such varied physical characteristics
- B.** To describe the specific habitat where Dubautia carrii are found and identify other plants that share a common ancestor with them
- C.** To describe the silversword alliance and explain how the plant family became so varied
- D.** To advance the claim that all plants on the Hawaiian Islands are part of the silversword alliance and list possible ancestors of the plants that make up the alliance

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is C.
- " The text introduces the silversword alliance as a family of plants unique to the Hawaiian Islands, presenting those that mature into vines and those that mature into shrubs and trees as examples of different phenotypes.
- The text concludes by explaining that these plants are all descendants of "a single ancestral tarweed plant" that arrived 5 million years ago in the Hawaiian Islands, where a "wide variety of habitats" drove the plant's descendants to adapt and thus differentiate themselves, diversifying into a group of related but distinct species with different physical characteristics.

Tip

Ask what this sentence or passage is **DOING**, not just what it says. Name the function (introduce, support, complicate, concede, conclude) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: Although the text explains why the plants within the silversword alliance have varied physical characteristics, the text doesn't suggest that tarweed is the ancestor of all plants on the Hawaiian Islands. The text states instead that all members of the silversword alliance descend from a single tarweed ancestor.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	To indicate the specific tarweed ancestor of all plants that grow on the Hawaiian Islands and explain why the plants have such varied physical characteristics	Choice A is incorrect. Although the text explains why the plants within the silversword alliance have varied physical characteristics, the text doesn't suggest that tarweed is the ancestor of all plants on the Hawaiian Islands. The text states instead that all members of the silversword alliance descend from a single tarweed ancestor.
X B	To describe the specific habitat where Dubautia carrii are found and identify other plants that share a common ancestor with them	Choice B is incorrect because while Dubautia carrii is mentioned as an example of a species in the silversword alliance, no details about its particular habitat are provided. And although the text indicates that the Hawaiian Islands are home to "a wide variety of habitats," it doesn't describe the specific habitat where Dubautia carrii is found. The text discusses the silversword alliance as a whole rather than focusing on Dubautia carrii or any one species within this family.

Question 1 — Process of Elimination (cont.)

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ C	To describe the silversword alliance and explain how the plant family became so varied	Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to describe the family of plants known as the silversword alliance and explain why the plants came to exhibit "an extraordinary range of phenotypes." The text introduces the silversword alliance as a family of plants unique to the Hawaiian Islands, presenting those that mature into vines and those that mature into shrubs and trees as examples of different phenotypes. The text concludes by explaining that these plants are all descendants of "a single ancestral tarweed plant" that arrived 5 million years ago in the Hawaiian Islands, where a "wide variety of habitats" drove the plant's descendants to adapt and thus differentiate themselves, diversifying into a group of related but distinct species with different physical characteristics.
✗ D	To advance the claim that all plants on the Hawaiian Islands are part of the silversword alliance and list possible ancestors of the plants that make up the alliance	Choice D is incorrect. Although the silversword alliance is only found on the Hawaiian Islands and includes "an extraordinary range of phenotypes," the text doesn't claim that all plants on the Hawaiian Islands are part of the alliance. Furthermore, the text indicates that these plants all "descended from a single ancestral tarweed plant," not that there are multiple possible candidates for that ancestor plant.

Question 2

Hard

Despite potential independent confirmation, the apparent detection in 2020 of phosphine (PH₃)—a gas that on Earth almost exclusively derives from biological sources—in Venus’s cloud deck remains controversial, in part because Venus is thought to be uninhabitable. To evaluate such a finding’s plausibility, William Bains et al. modeled multiple abiotic PH₃ pathways, including geochemical, atmospheric, and photochemical reactions, but none adequately explain the observed levels of PH₃. If Venusian PH₃ does exist, it would indicate insufficiencies in the current consensus on Venus’s chemistry.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A.** It outlines recent efforts to confirm the presence of a particular gas in Venus’s atmosphere, summarizes a research team’s evaluations of those efforts’ methodological shortcomings, and then explains why that team remains skeptical of the gas’s future detection.
- B.** It explains why the consensus view of a particular gas in Venus’s atmosphere has recently become controversial, expands on a scientific team’s reasons for questioning that consensus, and then suggests that future observations of Venus’s atmosphere will likely be needed to settle the controversy.
- C.** It introduces an unexpected observation of a particular gas in Venus’s atmosphere, presents an effort to investigate possible mechanisms that could explain that observation, and then notes an implication of that investigation’s findings.
- D.** It compares the levels of a particular gas on Venus and Earth, sketches the chemical processes that account for differences in these levels, and then addresses some of the practical challenges of studying the presence of this gas on Venus more closely.

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is C.
- It most accurately describes the overall structure of the text.
- The text begins by discussing the detection of phosphine gas in Venus's atmosphere, indicating that it is unexpected because on Earth, phosphine derives from biological sources, and Venus is thought to be uninhabitable, thereby lacking in biological sources.
- The text then presents the effort by Bains et al.
- To determine whether one or more abiotic (nonbiological) pathways could explain the observed levels of phosphine on Venus, noting that none could.
- Finally, the text notes an implication: if phosphine exists on Venus, its presence would indicate that our current understanding of chemical processes on Venus that could produce it is inadequate.
- Thus, the text introduces an unexpected observation about Venus's atmosphere, presents an effort to investigate mechanisms related to that observation, and notes an implication of that effort's findings.

Tip

Ask what this sentence or passage is DOING, not just what it says. Name the function (introduce, support, complicate, concede, conclude) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: The text starts by mentioning that phosphine has been detected in Venus's atmosphere. Rather than discuss whether the presence of phosphine on Venus can be confirmed, the text focuses on the efforts of one team of researchers, Bains et al., who are trying to explain the observed amount of phosphine on Venus. Furthermore, the text doesn't suggest that the research team was skeptical about the presence of phosphine on Venus.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	It outlines recent efforts to confirm the presence of a particular gas in Venus’s atmosphere, summarizes a research team’s evaluations of those efforts’ methodological shortcomings, and then explains why that team remains skeptical of the gas’s future detection.	Choice A is incorrect. The text starts by mentioning that phosphine has been detected in Venus’s atmosphere. Rather than discuss whether the presence of phosphine on Venus can be confirmed, the text focuses on the efforts of one team of researchers, Bains et al., who are trying to explain the observed amount of phosphine on Venus. Furthermore, the text doesn’t suggest that the research team was skeptical about the presence of phosphine on Venus.
X B	It explains why the consensus view of a particular gas in Venus’s atmosphere has recently become controversial, expands on a scientific team’s reasons for questioning that consensus, and then suggests that future observations of Venus’s atmosphere will likely be needed to settle the controversy.	Choice B is incorrect because, rather than indicating a consensus view about the phosphine detected on Venus, the text focuses on the fact that the detection “remains controversial,” a framing that suggests the controversy is not a new phenomenon. The text also doesn’t suggest that future atmospheric observations would be needed to settle the controversy. There is no consensus view about the presence of phosphine on Venus.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination (cont.)

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ C	It introduces an unexpected observation of a particular gas in Venus’s atmosphere, presents an effort to investigate possible mechanisms that could explain that observation, and then notes an implication of that investigation’s findings.	Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes the overall structure of the text. The text begins by discussing the detection of phosphine gas in Venus’s atmosphere, indicating that it is unexpected because on Earth, phosphine derives from biological sources, and Venus is thought to be uninhabitable, thereby lacking in biological sources. The text then presents the effort by Bains et al. to determine whether one or more abiotic (nonbiological) pathways could explain the observed levels of phosphine on Venus, noting that none could. Finally, the text notes an implication: if phosphine exists on Venus, its presence would indicate that our current understanding of chemical processes on Venus that could produce it is inadequate. Thus, the text introduces an unexpected observation about Venus’s atmosphere, presents an effort to investigate mechanisms related to that observation, and notes an implication of that effort’s findings.
✗ D	It compares the levels of a particular gas on Venus and Earth, sketches the chemical processes that account for differences in these levels, and then addresses some of the practical challenges of studying the presence of this gas on Venus more closely.	Choice D is incorrect because the text does not compare levels of phosphine on Venus with levels on Earth, nor does it address practical challenges of studying the gas on Venus.

Question 3

Hard

The mimosa tree evolved in East Asia, where the beetle *Bruchidius terrenus* preys on its seeds. In 1785, mimosa trees were introduced to North America, far from any *B. terrenus*. But evolutionary links between predators and their prey can persist across centuries and continents. Around 2001, *B. terrenus* was introduced in southeastern North America near where botanist Shu-Mei Chang and colleagues had been monitoring mimosa trees. Within a year, 93 percent of the trees had been attacked by the beetles.

Which choice best describes the function of the third sentence in the overall structure of the text?

- A.** It states the hypothesis that Chang and colleagues had set out to investigate using mimosa trees and *B. terrenus*.
- B.** It presents a generalization that is exemplified by the discussion of the mimosa trees and *B. terrenus*.
- C.** It provides context that clarifies why the species mentioned spread to new locations.
- D.** It offers an alternative explanation for the findings of Chang and colleagues.

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is B.
- It most accurately describes the function of the third sentence within the overall structure of the text.
- The third sentence makes a generalization, asserting that evolutionary links between predators and prey can persist across great expanses of time and distance.
- This generalization is exemplified by the text's discussion of the relationship between mimosa trees and B.
- Terrenus beetles.
- When mimosa trees were introduced to North America in 1785, no B.
- Terrenus beetles were present, so the relationship between the trees and the beetles that exists in their native East Asia was disrupted.

Tip

Ask what this sentence or passage is **DOING**, not just what it says. Name the function (introduce, support, complicate, concede, conclude) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: the third sentence doesn't indicate that Chang and colleagues were investigating any hypothesis. According to the text, Chang and colleagues were simply monitoring mimosa trees when the beetles happened to be introduced to the area.

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	It states the hypothesis that Chang and colleagues had set out to investigate using mimosa trees and B. terrenus.	Choice A is incorrect because the third sentence doesn't indicate that Chang and colleagues were investigating any hypothesis. According to the text, Chang and colleagues were simply monitoring mimosa trees when the beetles happened to be introduced to the area.
✓ B	It presents a generalization that is exemplified by the discussion of the mimosa trees and B. terrenus.	Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes the function of the third sentence within the overall structure of the text. The third sentence makes a generalization, asserting that evolutionary links between predators and prey can persist across great expanses of time and distance. This generalization is exemplified by the text's discussion of the relationship between mimosa trees and B. terrenus beetles. When mimosa trees were introduced to North America in 1785, no B. terrenus beetles were present, so the relationship between the trees and the beetles that exists in their native East Asia was disrupted. When the beetles were introduced to North America more than 200 years later, however, they quickly attacked mimosa trees, illustrating the generalization that links between predators and prey "can persist across centuries and continents."

Question 3 — Process of Elimination (cont.)

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X C	It provides context that clarifies why the species mentioned spread to new locations.	Choice C is incorrect because the third sentence doesn't discuss any particular species, let alone the species mentioned elsewhere in the text, nor does the sentence explain why species spread to new locations.
X D	It offers an alternative explanation for the findings of Chang and colleagues.	Choice D is incorrect because the third sentence offers a generalization about the relationship between predators and prey, not an explanation for the findings by Chang and colleagues that's an "alternative" to an explanation presented elsewhere in the text.

Question 4

Hard

The following text is from John Dryden's 1697 translation of Virgil's poem the Aeneid, written in the first century BCE. Queen Dido has just heard the Trojan hero Aeneas recount a sad tale. But anxious cares already seized the queen: She fed within her veins a flame unseen; The hero's valor, acts, and birth inspire Her soul with love, and fan the secret fire. His words, his looks, imprinted in her heart, Improve the passion, and increase the smart.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A.** To indicate that Dido is hiding her skepticism of Aeneas's account
- B.** To emphasize that Dido has been deeply affected by Aeneas's story
- C.** To imply that Dido engages both emotionally and intellectually with Aeneas
- D.** To suggest that Dido is worried that Aeneas might discover a secret she is keeping from him

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is B.
- It most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to foreground Queen Dido's strong emotional response to Aeneas's story.
- Throughout, the text emphasizes how deeply the queen is affected by both Aeneas's tale and persona.
- Seized the queen" and then uses the metaphor of fire ("within her veins a flame unseen" and "secret fire") to evoke the warmth of Dido's feelings for Aeneas.
- In addition, the line "His words, his looks, imprinted in her heart" suggests the deep impression that Aeneas's story makes on Dido, eliciting passion for him ("improving the passion") and empathy for his suffering ("increasing the smart").

Tip

Ask what this sentence or passage is **DOING**, not just what it says. Name the function (introduce, support, complicate, concede, conclude) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: there's no indication in the text that Dido is skeptical of Aeneas's account, much less that she's trying to conceal that skepticism. On the contrary, the text shows her being moved by his words and developing feelings for him.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	To indicate that Dido is hiding her skepticism of Aeneas’s account	Choice A is incorrect because there’s no indication in the text that Dido is skeptical of Aeneas’s account, much less that she’s trying to conceal that skepticism. On the contrary, the text shows her being moved by his words and developing feelings for him.
✓ B	To emphasize that Dido has been deeply affected by Aeneas’s story	Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to foreground Queen Dido’s strong emotional response to Aeneas’s story. Throughout, the text emphasizes how deeply the queen is affected by both Aeneas’s tale and persona. At the outset, the speaker explicitly states that "anxious cares...seized the queen" and then uses the metaphor of fire ("within her veins a flame unseen" and "secret fire") to evoke the warmth of Dido’s feelings for Aeneas. In addition, the line "His words, his looks, imprinted in her heart" suggests the deep impression that Aeneas’s story makes on Dido, eliciting passion for him ("improving the passion") and empathy for his suffering ("increase the smart").

Question 4 — Process of Elimination (cont.)

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X C	To imply that Dido engages both emotionally and intellectually with Aeneas	Choice C is incorrect. While the text mentions that Dido is impressed by Aeneas's "valor, acts, and birth," which might suggest (but doesn't necessarily entail) intellectual engagement, the text doesn't represent Dido's engagement with Aeneas in a manner that suggests a balance between emotion and intellect. Rather, the text primarily emphasizes her emotional response—specifically her attraction to Aeneas and her emotional investment in his story, indicating that his "valor, acts, and birth inspire / Her soul with love, and fan the secret fire" and that his words and looks elicit passion and empathy.
X D	To suggest that Dido is worried that Aeneas might discover a secret she is keeping from him	Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn't suggest that Dido is worried about Aeneas discovering a secret she is concealing from him. Though the text begins by mentioning Dido's "anxious cares," this refers to her growing passion for Aeneas and pity for his suffering, not to worry about a secret she is concealing. The text's reference to a "flame unseen" and "secret fire" points to Dido's growing feelings for Aeneas.

Question 5

Hard

Asteroid 6478 Gault has experienced intermittent mass loss since at least 2013, but in contrast to some other asteroids with repeated mass-loss episodes, 6478 Gault has not lost mass at its perihelion (the closest point of its orbit to the Sun), and thus the loss is not attributable to solar energy-driven ice vaporization. And as Jane X. Luu et al. point out, the singular nature of impact ejection makes it untenable as an account of multiple loss episodes of similar duration over several years. Instead, Luu et al. are likely correct that 6478 Gault is shedding mass due to rotational instability.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A.** It presents a scientific observation, describes a contrast between that observation and other observations, and then explains why those other observations should not be considered credible.
- B.** It describes an astronomical finding, discusses competing theories about that finding that the author regards as flawed, and then describes new evidence that supports an alternative theory.
- C.** It introduces a natural phenomenon, refutes two potential explanations for that phenomenon, and then presents a third explanation for that phenomenon that the author regards as plausible.
- D.** It discusses a physical process, evaluates possible causes of that process, and then states that a persuasive account of the process has yet to be put forward.

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is C.
- It most accurately describes the overall structure of the text.
- The text begins by introducing the natural phenomenon of intermittent mass loss with regard to Asteroid 6478 Gault and notes that it curiously has not lost mass at its perihelion like other asteroids typically do.
- The text then refutes "solar energy-driven ice vaporization" and "the singular nature of impact ejection" as two possible explanations for Asteroid 6478 Gault's intermittent mass loss.
- " Thus, the overall structure of the text is that it introduces a natural phenomenon, refutes two potential explanations for that phenomenon, and then presents a third explanation for that phenomenon that the author regards as plausible.

Tip

Ask what this sentence or passage is DOING, not just what it says. Name the function (introduce, support, complicate, concede, conclude) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: the text doesn't distinguish between multiple observations. It focuses on the single observation that Asteroid 6478 Gault is losing mass and evaluates multiple explanations for the phenomenon. The text also asserts that Luu et al.'s explanation is credible and "likely correct."

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	It presents a scientific observation, describes a contrast between that observation and other observations, and then explains why those other observations should not be considered credible.	Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn't distinguish between multiple observations. It focuses on the single observation that Asteroid 6478 Gault is losing mass and evaluates multiple explanations for the phenomenon. The text also asserts that Luu et al.'s explanation is credible and "likely correct."
X B	It describes an astronomical finding, discusses competing theories about that finding that the author regards as flawed, and then describes new evidence that supports an alternative theory.	Choice B is incorrect because the text describes a natural phenomenon, not a specific astronomical finding. In addition, although the text does note flawed reasons for Asteroid 6478 Gault's intermittent mass loss, it doesn't mention that Asteroid 6478 Gault's intermittent mass loss is based on new evidence.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination (cont.)

Correct answer: C

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ C	It introduces a natural phenomenon, refutes two potential explanations for that phenomenon, and then presents a third explanation for that phenomenon that the author regards as plausible.	Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes the overall structure of the text. The text begins by introducing the natural phenomenon of intermittent mass loss with regard to Asteroid 6478 Gault and notes that it curiously has not lost mass at its perihelion like other asteroids typically do. The text then refutes "solar energy-driven ice vaporization" and "the singular nature of impact ejection" as two possible explanations for Asteroid 6478 Gault’s intermittent mass loss. Finally, the text presents Luu et al.’s explanation that "6478 Gault is shedding mass due to rotational instability," which the author says is "likely correct." Thus, the overall structure of the text is that it introduces a natural phenomenon, refutes two potential explanations for that phenomenon, and then presents a third explanation for that phenomenon that the author regards as plausible.
✗ D	It discusses a physical process, evaluates possible causes of that process, and then states that a persuasive account of the process has yet to be put forward.	Choice D is incorrect. Although the text does evaluate explanations for the cause of Asteroid 6478 Gault’s intermittent mass loss, the text also asserts that Luu et al.’s explanation that they have put forth is persuasive and "likely correct."

Question 6

Hard

Vadamalai Elangovan and Ganapathi Marimuthu showed that high moonlight intensity inhibits the activity of the greater short-nosed fruit bat (*Cynopterus sphinx*), a result explicable in terms of benefits and costs: greater lunar intensity may not enable the bats to increase foraging success enough to offset the higher chance of detection by predatory owls or hawks. Most other nocturnal mammals respond to lunar intensity variations similarly to greater short-nosed fruit bats, but mongoose lemurs (*Eulemur mongoz*) display the opposite pattern, as their heavy reliance on visual foraging results in a different balance of reward and risk.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A.** It discusses two different responses to the same natural phenomenon, explains why one of those responses occurs, and then suggests that the other response still needs to be explained.
- B.** It describes and accounts for a finding, characterizes the finding as representative of a general pattern, and then describes and accounts for an exception to that pattern.
- C.** It presents and explains a study result, indicates that the result is similar to the results of many other studies, and then attributes a conflicting study result to a difference in that study's methods.
- D.** It introduces an observation of a behavioral pattern, presents an explanation for the pattern, and then describes an exception to the pattern that casts doubt on that explanation.

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is B.
- It most accurately describes the overall structure of the text.
- The text begins by describing a study's finding about greater short-nosed fruit bats—namely, that high moonlight intensity inhibits the bats' activity—and also accounts for that finding, stating that this occurs because the potential increase in foraging success that greater lunar intensity enables doesn't offset these bats' increased vulnerability to predators (whose vision is also implied to become more acute under intense moonlight).
- The text goes on to characterize this finding as representative of a general pattern, stating that many nocturnal mammals behave similarly in response to changes in lunar intensity.
- The text concludes by describing an exception to this pattern, explaining that mongoose lemurs display an opposite tendency because they rely heavily on visual foraging.
- This strategy presumably would allow them to derive more benefit from greater lunar intensity than many other nocturnal mammals would, resulting in a "different balance of reward and risk" than exists for other nocturnal mammals.
- Therefore, the overall structure of the text is best described as a description and account of a finding, a characterization of that finding as representative of a pattern, and then a description and account of an exception to that pattern.

Question 6 — Rule, Tip & Trap

Tip

Ask what this sentence or passage is DOING, not just what it says. Name the function (introduce, support, complicate, concede, conclude) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: Although the text discusses two different responses to variations in moonlight intensity, explaining that as moonlight intensity increases, greater short-nosed fruit bats and many other nocturnal mammals decrease their foraging activity but mongoose lemurs increase their foraging activity, it doesn't leave one of these responses unexplained. The text accounts for both the typical response to increased lunar intensity (reduced activity due to predation risk) and the exception (increased activity due to a reliance on visual foraging) by making reference to a cost-benefit framework.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	It discusses two different responses to the same natural phenomenon, explains why one of those responses occurs, and then suggests that the other response still needs to be explained.	Choice A is incorrect. Although the text discusses two different responses to variations in moonlight intensity, explaining that as moonlight intensity increases, greater short-nosed fruit bats and many other nocturnal mammals decrease their foraging activity but mongoose lemurs increase their foraging activity, it doesn't leave one of these responses unexplained. The text accounts for both the typical response to increased lunar intensity (reduced activity due to predation risk) and the exception (increased activity due to a reliance on visual foraging) by making reference to a cost-benefit framework.
✓ B	It describes and accounts for a finding, characterizes the finding as representative of a general pattern, and then describes and accounts for an exception to that pattern.	Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes the overall structure of the text. The text begins by describing a study's finding about greater short-nosed fruit bats—namely, that high moonlight intensity inhibits the bats' activity—and also accounts for that finding, stating that this occurs because the potential increase in foraging success that greater lunar intensity enables doesn't offset these bats' increased vulnerability to predators (whose vision is also implied to become more acute under intense moonlight). The text goes on to characterize this finding as representative of a general pattern, stating that many nocturnal mammals behave similarly in response to changes in lunar intensity. The text concludes by describing an exception to this pattern, explaining that mongoose lemurs display an opposite tendency because they rely heavily on visual foraging. This strategy presumably would allow them to derive more benefit from greater lunar intensity than many other nocturnal mammals would, resulting in a "different balance of reward and risk" than exists for other nocturnal mammals. Therefore, the overall structure of the text is best described as a description and account of a finding, a characterization of that finding as representative of a pattern, and then a description and account of an exception to that pattern.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination (cont.)

Correct answer: B

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X C	It presents and explains a study result, indicates that the result is similar to the results of many other studies, and then attributes a conflicting study result to a difference in that study's methods.	Choice C is incorrect. Although the text presents a study's finding about the effect of increased lunar intensity on greater short-nosed fruit bats' activity before going on to contrast this behavior with the fact that mongoose lemurs display the opposite response to increased lunar intensity, the text doesn't explicitly invoke other studies and doesn't attribute this difference in observed behavior to the fact that the study of greater short-nosed fruit bats used different methods than studies of mongoose lemurs did. Rather, the text explains that the different observed behaviors can be attributed to differences in species' foraging strategies.
X D	It introduces an observation of a behavioral pattern, presents an explanation for the pattern, and then describes an exception to the pattern that casts doubt on that explanation.	Choice D is incorrect.

Question 7

Hard

Pteropods are small swimming snails with thin, delicate calcium carbonate shells. These animals are thought to be especially vulnerable to ocean acidification due to calcium carbonate's susceptibility to dissolution at lower pH values. Victoria L. Peck and colleagues recently found that the periostracum (a protective coating on pteropods' outer shells) prevents this dissolution when intact. Moreover, the team was surprised to discover that even when the periostracum is breached, pteropods can still mitigate damage by rebuilding the inner shell wall.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A.** To call for additional research on biological mechanisms that improve pteropod survival rates
- B.** To discuss a conclusion drawn in a study of calcium carbonate's role in protecting the periostracum of pteropods
- C.** To address some of the ways ocean acidification has altered pteropod behavior over time
- D.** To present findings that suggest that a concern about the effects of ocean acidification on pteropod shells may be unwarranted

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is D.
- It most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to present findings that suggest a previously held concern about the effects of ocean acidification on pteropod shells may be unwarranted.
- The text introduces the concern that pteropods are thought to be particularly vulnerable to ocean acidification, or lower pH levels, due to the susceptibility of their calcium carbonate shells to dissolution at lower pH levels.
- However, the text then describes findings from a recent study that suggest this concern may be unjustified, insofar as the protective periostracum coating on a pteropod's shell prevents dissolution, and even when the coating is breached, a pteropod can rebuild the inner shell wall, reducing the damage.

Tip

Ask what this sentence or passage is **DOING**, not just what it says. Name the function (introduce, support, complicate, concede, conclude) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: the text doesn't call for additional research or suggest that more research is needed on biological mechanisms that improve pteropod survival rates. Instead, the text discusses a recent study showing that pteropods may not be as vulnerable to ocean acidification as is feared.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: D

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	To call for additional research on biological mechanisms that improve pteropod survival rates	Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn't call for additional research or suggest that more research is needed on biological mechanisms that improve pteropod survival rates. Instead, the text discusses a recent study showing that pteropods may not be as vulnerable to ocean acidification as is feared.
X B	To discuss a conclusion drawn in a study of calcium carbonate's role in protecting the periostracum of pteropods	Choice B is incorrect because the study discussed in the text doesn't address calcium carbonate's role in protecting the periostracum of pteropods. According to the text, the study addresses the periostracum's role in protecting pteropods' calcium carbonate shells from dissolution due to ocean acidification.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination (cont.)

Correct answer: **D**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X C	To address some of the ways ocean acidification has altered pteropod behavior over time	Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn't address how ocean acidification has altered pteropod behavior over time. Instead, the text focuses on the potential effects of ocean acidification on pteropods' shells and the mechanisms protecting against those effects.
✓ D	To present findings that suggest that a concern about the effects of ocean acidification on pteropod shells may be unwarranted	Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to present findings that suggest a previously held concern about the effects of ocean acidification on pteropod shells may be unwarranted. The text introduces the concern that pteropods are thought to be particularly vulnerable to ocean acidification, or lower pH levels, due to the susceptibility of their calcium carbonate shells to dissolution at lower pH levels. However, the text then describes findings from a recent study that suggest this concern may be unjustified, insofar as the protective periostracum coating on a pteropod's shell prevents dissolution, and even when the coating is breached, a pteropod can rebuild the inner shell wall, reducing the damage.

Question 8

Hard

The following text is from Charlotte Brontë's 1847 novel *Jane Eyre*. Jane, the narrator, works as a governess at Thornfield Hall. I went on with my day's business tranquilly; but ever and anon vague suggestions kept wandering across my brain of reasons why I should quit Thornfield; and I kept involuntarily framing advertisements and pondering conjectures about new situations: these thoughts I did not think to check; they might germinate and bear fruit if they could.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A.** To convey a contrast between Jane's outward calmness and internal restlessness
- B.** To emphasize Jane's loyalty to the people she works for at Thornfield Hall
- C.** To demonstrate that Jane finds her situation both challenging and deeply fulfilling
- D.** To describe Jane's determination to secure employment outside of Thornfield Hall

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is A.
- It most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to show that while Jane calmly goes about her daily tasks, she is experiencing internal agitation about possibly seeking a new job.
- At the start of the text, Jane says, “I went on with my day’s business tranquilly,” indicating that she is outwardly calm.
- This outward calmness is then contrasted with her intense internal restlessness, as Jane says that thoughts of leaving her job keep running through her mind, that she is “involuntarily framing advertisements” (meaning that she can’t stop herself from thinking up potential listings for jobs), and that she often wonders what new “situations” (or jobs) would be like.

Tip

Ask what this sentence or passage is **DOING**, not just what it says. Name the function (introduce, support, complicate, concede, conclude) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice B is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: the text gives no indication of Jane’s feelings, either positive or negative, about the people she works for at Thornfield Hall. And rather than emphasizing that Jane feels particularly loyal to her employers, the text focuses on her constant consideration of leaving her job.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	To convey a contrast between Jane’s outward calmness and internal restlessness	Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to show that while Jane calmly goes about her daily tasks, she is experiencing internal agitation about possibly seeking a new job. At the start of the text, Jane says, “I went on with my day’s business tranquilly,” indicating that she is outwardly calm. This outward calmness is then contrasted with her intense internal restlessness, as Jane says that thoughts of leaving her job keep running through her mind, that she is “involuntarily framing advertisements” (meaning that she can’t stop herself from thinking up potential listings for jobs), and that she often wonders what new “situations” (or jobs) would be like.
✗ B	To emphasize Jane’s loyalty to the people she works for at Thornfield Hall	Choice B is incorrect because the text gives no indication of Jane’s feelings, either positive or negative, about the people she works for at Thornfield Hall. And rather than emphasizing that Jane feels particularly loyal to her employers, the text focuses on her constant consideration of leaving her job.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination (cont.)

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X C	To demonstrate that Jane finds her situation both challenging and deeply fulfilling	Choice C is incorrect because the text gives no indication that Jane finds her current situation fulfilling, or satisfying. Given that much of the text is focused on Jane’s thoughts about possibly leaving her job for a new one, it might be the case that she finds her situation challenging, but there is no evidence in the text that Jane also finds that situation satisfying—she says nothing positive about her current job at all, in fact.
X D	To describe Jane’s determination to secure employment outside of Thornfield Hall	Choice D is incorrect because the text describes Jane as wondering about getting a new job, not as determined to definitely do so. Jane keeps thinking about reasons why she “should” quit her current job (indicating that she hasn’t yet decided to) and imagining possible new situations she could find, but she says at the end of the text that these thoughts “might germinate and bear fruit if they could,” meaning that the thoughts haven’t yet led to a decision—that Jane isn’t yet determined to get a new job somewhere else.

Quick Review — Text Structure and Purpose

At a Glance

Tests authorial intention, not content. Your #1 move: ask "what is this DOING?" not "what does this say?"

Common words: *up to 4 questions/test*

Top Rules — Never Forget

- Ask "what is this DOING?" not "what does it say?"
- Memorize the verbs: introduce, support, challenge, concede, conclude.
- "However" → challenge; "for example" → illustrate.
- Apply the disappearance test to underlined or highlighted sentences.
- Eliminate answers that introduce ideas not in the passage.

SECTION 3

Cross-Text Connections

Theory + 8 Worked Questions

Cross-Text Connections

1- 4 questions per test • these questions test the intellectual relationship between two short texts on a related topic — not just what each text says, but how the second text would engage with the first.

What the question looks like

"Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the argument in Text 1?"

"How would the author of Text 1 most likely describe the approach taken by the researchers in Text 2?"

What the Exam Is Really Testing

- Cross-Text Connections questions test whether you can identify the RELATIONSHIP between two authors' claims — agreement, disagreement, extension, qualification.
- Write a one-sentence summary of each text's claim BEFORE looking at the choices — this is the single highest-leverage habit for this skill.
- Check direction carefully: "how would the author of Text 2 respond to Text 1" is not the same question as "how would the author of Text 1 respond to Text 2."

By the numbers — from 45 real Cross-Text Connections questions

Just under half (49%) of real questions use explicit "respond" framing ("How would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to..."). Cross-Text Connections skews Hard (71%) but is meaningfully less Hard-dominated than Words in Context or Text Structure and Purpose — a modest but real fraction (13%) are rated Easy.

Relationship Types

Agreement Both texts reach the same conclusion.	Disagreement Text 2 refutes Text 1's central claim.
Extension Text 2 adds depth or breadth to Text 1's idea.	Qualification Text 2 accepts but limits or nuances Text 1's claim.
Application Text 2 applies Text 1's idea to a new case.	Problem → Response Text 2 answers a concern Text 1 raises.

Method

- Read each text fully before comparing them — don't start drawing conclusions halfway through Text 1.
- Think of a one-sentence summary of each text's claim — this pair of summaries usually IS your answer, once you name how they relate.
- Name the relationship type (from the table above) before reading the answer choices.
- Reject any choice that overstates the relationship — a text that raises one limitation is "qualifying," not "refuting."
- Watch for choices that mix up which author said what — a very common wrong-answer construction.

WORKED QUESTIONS

Cross-Text Connections — 8 Worked Questions

Question → Explanation, Rule, Tip & Trap → Process of Elimination

Question 1

Hard

Text 1

Many studies in psychology have shown that people seek out information even when they know in advance that they have no immediate use for it and that they won't directly benefit from it. Such findings support the consensus view among researchers of curiosity: namely, that curiosity is not instrumental but instead represents a drive to acquire information for its own sake.

Text 2

While acknowledging that acquiring information is a powerful motivator, Rachit Dubey and colleagues ran an experiment to test whether emphasizing the usefulness of scientific information could increase curiosity about it. They found that when research involving rats and fruit flies was presented as having medical applications for humans, participants expressed greater interest in learning about it than when the research was not presented as useful.

Based on the texts, how would Dubey and colleagues (Text 2) most likely respond to the consensus view discussed in Text 1?

- A.** By suggesting that curiosity may not be exclusively motivated by the desire to merely acquire information
- B.** By conceding that people may seek out information that serves no immediate purpose only because they think they can use it later
- C.** By pointing out that it is challenging to determine when information-seeking serves no goal beyond acquiring information
- D.** By disputing the idea that curiosity can help explain apparently purposeless information-seeking behaviors

Question 1 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is A.
- The researchers in Text 2 recognize that acquiring information is a powerful motivator, but showed that this motivation can still be affected by other factors, like whether or not the information is expected to be useful or not.
- This suggests that other desires may play a part in driving people to acquire information.

Tip

Write a one-sentence summary of each text's claim first, then name the relationship between them (agree, disagree, qualify, extend) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice B is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: The consensus view in Text 1 is that people acquire information regardless of whether they think they can use it later. Dubey and colleagues acknowledge this fact (so they don't claim people seek out information "only" because it might be useful later).

Question 1 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	By suggesting that curiosity may not be exclusively motivated by the desire to merely acquire information	Choice A is the best answer. The researchers in Text 2 recognize that acquiring information is a powerful motivator, but showed that this motivation can still be affected by other factors, like whether or not the information is expected to be useful or not. This suggests that other desires may play a part in driving people to acquire information.
✗ B	By conceding that people may seek out information that serves no immediate purpose only because they think they can use it later	Choice B is incorrect. The consensus view in Text 1 is that people acquire information regardless of whether they think they can use it later. Dubey and colleagues acknowledge this fact (so they don't claim people seek out information "only" because it might be useful later).
✗ C	By pointing out that it is challenging to determine when information-seeking serves no goal beyond acquiring information	Choice C is incorrect. This choice misreads the results of Dubey and colleagues' study in Text 2. Neither text discusses the difficulty of determining the motivation for information-seeking.
✗ D	By disputing the idea that curiosity can help explain apparently purposeless information-seeking behaviors	Choice D is incorrect. This choice contradicts Text 2, which starts with Dubey and colleagues "acknowledging that acquiring information is a powerful motivator" (i.e., agreeing that curiosity explains the seeking of apparently purposeless information). The research in Text 2 simply suggests that more than just curiosity can motivate information-seeking behavior when the information has a purpose.

Question 2

Hard

Text 1

Philosopher G.E. Moore's most influential work entails the concept of common sense. He asserts that there are certain beliefs that all people, including philosophers, know instinctively to be true, whether or not they profess otherwise: among them, that they have bodies, or that they exist in a world with other objects that have three dimensions. Moore's careful work on common sense may seem obvious but was in fact groundbreaking.

Text 2

External world skepticism is a philosophical stance supposing that we cannot be sure of the existence of anything outside our own minds. During a lecture, G.E. Moore once offered a proof refuting this stance by holding out his hands and saying, "Here is one hand, and here is another." Many philosophers reflexively reject this proof (Annalisa Coliva called it "an obviously annoying failure") but have found it a challenge to articulate exactly why the proof fails.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 1 most likely respond to proponents of the philosophical stance outlined in Text 2?

- A.** By agreeing with those proponents that Moore's treatment of positions that contradict his own is fundamentally unserious
- B.** By suggesting that an instinctive distaste for Moore's position is preventing external world skeptics from constructing a sufficiently rigorous refutation of Moore
- C.** By arguing that if it is valid to assert that some facts are true based on instinct, it is also valid to assert that some proofs are inadequate based on instinct
- D.** By pointing out that Moore would assert that external world skepticism is at odds with other beliefs those proponents must unavoidably hold

Question 2 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is D.
- ” So it’s safe to infer that the author would observe that Moore would respond to external world skeptics by arguing that since everyone instinctively knows that things exist outside of their own minds, then external world skepticism must be wrong.

Tip

Write a one-sentence summary of each text's claim first, then name the relationship between them (agree, disagree, qualify, extend) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: We can’t infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to external world skeptics. If anything, the author of Text 1 seems to agree with Moore.

Question 2 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: D

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	By agreeing with those proponents that Moore’s treatment of positions that contradict his own is fundamentally unserious	Choice A is incorrect. We can’t infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to external world skeptics. If anything, the author of Text 1 seems to agree with Moore.
X B	By suggesting that an instinctive distaste for Moore’s position is preventing external world skeptics from constructing a sufficiently rigorous refutation of Moore	Choice B is incorrect. We can’t infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to external world skeptics. The author of Text 1 never mentions external world skeptics directly, let alone why they have a hard time refuting Moore’s position.
X C	By arguing that if it is valid to assert that some facts are true based on instinct, it is also valid to assert that some proofs are inadequate based on instinct	Choice C is incorrect. We can’t infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to external world skeptics. Text 1’s presentation of Moore’s concept of common sense only includes the idea that some facts are true based on instinct—it doesn’t mention the idea that some proofs are inadequate based on instinct.
✓ D	By pointing out that Moore would assert that external world skepticism is at odds with other beliefs those proponents must unavoidably hold	Choice D is the best answer. According to the author of Text 1, Moore’s definition of common sense—things we instinctively know are true— includes the belief that we all “exist in a world with other objects.” The author of Text 1 describes this notion as both “obvious” and “groundbreaking.” So it’s safe to infer that the author would observe that Moore would respond to external world skeptics by arguing that since everyone instinctively knows that things exist outside of their own minds, then external world skepticism must be wrong.

Question 3

Hard

Text 1

Mycoprotein is a fungal biomass that can be eaten as an alternative to meat. Studies of the environmental impact of its manufacture generally agree it is lower than that of beef and closer to that of chicken or pork. But the expense of producing mycoprotein restricts its availability to a few countries with postindustrial economies. Knowing that cost reductions would expand access to mycoprotein, biochemists are exploring solutions, such as a cheaper substrate to feed the mycoprotein as it grows.

Text 2

Cattle farming is a principal cause of global deforestation, and a study by Florian Humpenöder and his colleagues found that replacing 20% of beef consumption worldwide with consumption of mycoprotein would cut deforestation by half if accomplished over the next thirty years. However, this would likely involve only a small change in agricultural water consumption, since water once dedicated to raising cattle would be diverted to raising crops instead.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 1 most likely respond to the study findings mentioned in Text 2?

- A.** By emphasizing that since agricultural water consumption would remain static in the event of replacing beef consumption with mycoprotein consumption, an effort must be made to substitute mycoprotein for chicken and pork in diets as well
- B.** By asserting that the development of a more inexpensive substrate for mycoprotein production would contribute to the goal of decreasing worldwide deforestation over time
- C.** By noting that most people would be more likely to use mycoprotein as a substitute for chicken or pork in their diets than as a substitute for beef
- D.** By pointing out that some countries are responsible for greater deforestation than others and thus, to have any significant effect on the environment, will have to replace more than 20% of their beef consumption with mycoprotein

Question 3 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is B.
- It reflects how the author of Text 1 would most likely respond to the study findings described in Text 2.
- The author of Text 2 discusses a study by Florian Humpenöder and his colleagues that found that deforestation would be reduced by half over the next thirty years if 20% of the beef consumed worldwide were replaced with mycoprotein.
- The author of Text 1 points out that mycoprotein is not widely available because of its high production cost, but goes on to note that this problem could be addressed by the creation of a cheaper substrate to feed mycoprotein.
- This suggests that the author of Text 1 would assert that the development of a less expensive mycoprotein substrate would contribute to the reduction in deforestation described in the study findings discussed in Text 2: if reducing the cost of mycoprotein increases people's access to it, then mycoprotein may be able to replace beef in more people's diets, thereby reducing the deforestation associated with beef production.

Tip

Write a one-sentence summary of each text's claim first, then name the relationship between them (agree, disagree, qualify, extend) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: the author of Text 1 indicates that the environmental impact of mycoprotein production is close to that of chicken or pork production, so there is no reason to think that the author would assert that replacing chicken or pork with mycoprotein would be

Question 3 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	By emphasizing that since agricultural water consumption would remain static in the event of replacing beef consumption with mycoprotein consumption, an effort must be made to substitute mycoprotein for chicken and pork in diets as well	Choice A is incorrect because the author of Text 1 indicates that the environmental impact of mycoprotein production is close to that of chicken or pork production, so there is no reason to think that the author would assert that replacing chicken or pork with mycoprotein would be
✓ B	By asserting that the development of a more inexpensive substrate for mycoprotein production would contribute to the goal of decreasing worldwide deforestation over time	Choice B is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 1 would most likely respond to the study findings described in Text 2. The author of Text 2 discusses a study by Florian Humpenöder and his colleagues that found that deforestation would be reduced by half over the next thirty years if 20% of the beef consumed worldwide were replaced with mycoprotein. The author of Text 1 points out that mycoprotein is not widely available because of its high production cost, but goes on to note that this problem could be addressed by the creation of a cheaper substrate to feed mycoprotein. This suggests that the author of Text 1 would assert that the development of a less expensive mycoprotein substrate would contribute to the reduction in deforestation described in the study findings discussed in Text 2: if reducing the cost of mycoprotein increases people’s access to it, then mycoprotein may be able to replace beef in more people’s diets, thereby reducing the deforestation associated with beef production.

Question 4

Hard

Text 1

Hycean planets are a class of exoplanets (planets outside our solar system) with oceans of liquid water—critical to supporting life—and atmospheres rich in hydrogen. Computer models have determined that for potential hycean planets, the range of the habitable zone (HZ), the distance from a star that allows a planet to retain liquid water on its surface, begins at about 1 astronomical unit (AU). In 2021, Nikku Madhusudhan et al. identified K2-18 b as a hycean candidate, noting that the planet is located right on the inner edge of the HZ.

Text 2

In a 2023 paper, Shang-Min Tsai et al. claimed that the hydrogen-rich atmospheres of K2-18 b and other hycean candidates admit wavelengths of light that cause elevated surface temperatures and increased water evaporation. Unlike earlier assessments, Tsai et al.'s calculations therefore placed the inner edge for these planets' HZ as far out as 3.85 AU.

Based on the texts, how would Tsai et al. (Text 2) most likely respond to Madhusudhan et al.'s research, as presented in Text 1?

- A.** By stating that the chemical composition of the atmosphere of the hycean candidate Madhusudhan et al. identified suggests that this planet's surface is unlikely to harbor liquid water
- B.** By maintaining that Madhusudhan et al. relied on a model whose estimates of surface temperatures on hycean candidates are likely too high
- C.** By observing that unlike the hycean candidate Madhusudhan et al. discovered, most other types of planets with hydrogen-rich atmospheres are likely located within the HZ
- D.** By arguing that K2-18 b and other hycean candidates are unlikely to support life because these planets are located too far from the stars they orbit

Question 4 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is A.
- It reflects how Tsai et al.
- Text 1 establishes that the habitable zone (HZ) for potential hycean planets, which are typified by abundant liquid water and hydrogen-rich atmospheres, represents “the distance from a star that allows a planet to retain liquid water on its surface” and is estimated to begin at about 1 astronomical unit (AU).
- Identified K2-18 b as a hycean candidate whose location falls on the “inner edge” of the HZ—implying that its distance from its star is about 1 AU.
- ’s claim that the same hydrogen-rich atmospheres that typify K2-18 b and other hycean candidates “admit wavelengths of light that cause elevated surface temperatures and increased water evaporation,” phenomena that would be exacerbated by proximity to their host stars.
- Tsai et al. 85 AU,” implying that hycean candidates at lesser distances from their stars would be unlikely to maintain liquid oceans because of elevated surface temperatures and subsequent water evaporation.
- ’s HZ estimate, K2-18 b—at roughly 1 AU—would be too close to its star to retain liquid water.
- Therefore, based on the details in the texts, Tsai et al. Would most likely respond that the very atmospheric composition that defines K2-18 b as a hycean candidate suggests that it is unlikely to harbor liquid water on its surface.

Question 4 — Rule, Tip & Trap

Tip

Write a one-sentence summary of each text's claim first, then name the relationship between them (agree, disagree, qualify, extend) before reading the choices.

Question 4 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	By stating that the chemical composition of the atmosphere of the hycean candidate Madhusudhan et al. identified suggests that this planet’s surface is unlikely to harbor liquid water	Choice A is the best answer because it reflects how Tsai et al. would most likely respond to Madhusudhan et al.’s identification of K2-18 b as a hycean candidate. Text 1 establishes that the habitable zone (HZ) for potential hycean planets, which are typified by abundant liquid water and hydrogen-rich atmospheres, represents “the distance from a star that allows a planet to retain liquid water on its surface” and is estimated to begin at about 1 astronomical unit (AU). Based on this characterization of the HZ, Madhusudhan et al. identified K2-18 b as a hycean candidate whose location falls on the “inner edge” of the HZ—implying that its distance from its star is about 1 AU. However, Text 2 presents Tsai et al.’s claim that the same hydrogen-rich atmospheres that typify K2-18 b and other hycean candidates “admit wavelengths of light that cause elevated surface temperatures and increased water evaporation,” phenomena that would be exacerbated by proximity to their host stars. Tsai et al. instead placed the inner edge of the HZ “as far out as 3.85 AU,” implying that hycean candidates at lesser distances from their stars would be unlikely to maintain liquid oceans because of elevated surface temperatures and subsequent water evaporation. According to Tsai et al.’s HZ estimate, K2-18 b—at roughly 1 AU—would be too close to its star to retain liquid water. Therefore, based on the details in the texts, Tsai et al. would most likely respond that the very atmospheric composition that defines K2-18 b as a hycean candidate suggests that it is unlikely to harbor liquid water on its surface.

Question 5

Hard

Text 1

Many teleost fish species are protogynous, meaning that fertile females can become fertile males. One model holds that protogyny occurs when body size confers a greater reproductive advantage on males than on females. In teleost fish, body size is irrelevant to female reproduction, but among males (which tend to be larger than females), only individuals comparatively large enough to defend territory reproduce. An individual could thus maximize its lifetime reproductive success by staying female when small and becoming male upon reaching a critical size threshold.

Text 2

Investigating protogyny in teleost fish, Alexander Goikoetxea and colleagues placed captured spotty wrasses of typical size distributions into two mixed-sex tanks. During the breeding season, they removed all males from tank 1 but none from tank 2. They observed that sexual change began in 81 percent of females in tank 1 but in no females in tank 2.

Based on the texts, which choice best explains the difference in the outcomes of the two tanks in Goikoetxea and colleagues' experiment (Text 2) using the model presented in Text 1?

- A.** Once the males were removed from tank 1, territories in the tank were undefended and thus even small females could maximize their reproductive success by becoming male and taking over those territories, whereas only the largest females in tank 2 could successfully take over territories due to the ongoing presence of males in the tank.
- B.** With no males left in tank 1, females were potentially large enough to defend territory as males and thus could gain an advantage by becoming male at their current size, whereas females in tank 2 may not have been large enough to outcompete the males in the tank and thus would have greater reproductive success by remaining female.
- C.** Differences in body size among the females in tank 1 became irrelevant to reproductive success once the males were removed, thereby eliminating any advantage to becoming male, whereas the ongoing presence of males in tank 2 made differences in body size among the females in that tank relevant to their reproductive success.
- D.** Since all males were removed from tank 1, the females in the tank could not reproduce regardless of their size and thus some became male, whereas the presence of males in tank 2 meant that females in that tank could reproduce without first becoming male and thus they remained female.

Question 5 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is B.
- It correctly applies the model presented in Text 1 to explain the different outcomes in the two tanks described in Text 2.
- Text 1 begins by explaining that fertile female teleost fish will sometimes become fertile males through protogyny.
- The model, or explanation, of protogyny advanced in Text 1 holds that among female teleost fish, size doesn't confer any reproductive advantage, but among male teleost fish, "only individuals comparatively large enough to defend territory reproduce"—in other words, there is a direct relationship between relative body size and reproductive success, but only among male fish.
- Text 1 concludes by saying that, according to this model, individuals can maximize their reproductive success by "staying female when small" (when size has no relevance to reproduction) and only becoming male when they reach a certain size threshold by becoming large enough relative to other male fish to be able to defend territory.

Tip

Write a one-sentence summary of each text's claim first, then name the relationship between them (agree, disagree, qualify, extend) before reading the choices.

Question 5 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ B	With no males left in tank 1, females were potentially large enough to defend territory as males and thus could gain an advantage by becoming male at their current size, whereas females in tank 2 may not have been large enough to outcompete the males in the tank and thus would have greater reproductive success by remaining female.	Choice B is the best answer because it correctly applies the model presented in Text 1 to explain the different outcomes in the two tanks described in Text 2. Text 1 begins by explaining that fertile female teleost fish will sometimes become fertile males through protogyny. The model, or explanation, of protogyny advanced in Text 1 holds that among female teleost fish, size doesn’t confer any reproductive advantage, but among male teleost fish, “only individuals comparatively large enough to defend territory reproduce”—in other words, there is a direct relationship between relative body size and reproductive success, but only among male fish. Text 1 concludes by saying that, according to this model, individuals can maximize their reproductive success by “staying female when small” (when size has no relevance to reproduction) and only becoming male when they reach a certain size threshold by becoming large enough relative to other male fish to be able to defend territory. In

Question 6

Hard

Text 1

Ecologists have long wondered how thousands of microscopic phytoplankton species can live together near ocean surfaces competing for the same resources. According to conventional wisdom, one species should emerge after outcompeting the rest. So why do so many species remain? Ecologists' many efforts to explain this phenomenon still haven't uncovered a satisfactory explanation.

Text 2

Ecologist Michael Behrenfeld and colleagues have connected phytoplankton's diversity to their microscopic size. Because these organisms are so tiny, they are spaced relatively far apart from each other in ocean water and, moreover, experience that water as a relatively dense substance. This in turn makes it hard for them to move around and interact with one another. Therefore, says Behrenfeld's team, direct competition among phytoplankton probably happens much less than previously thought.

Based on the texts, how would Behrenfeld and colleagues (Text 2) most likely respond to the “conventional wisdom” discussed in Text 1?

- A.** By arguing that it is based on a misconception about phytoplankton species competing with one another
- B.** By asserting that it fails to recognize that routine replenishment of ocean nutrients prevents competition between phytoplankton species
- C.** By suggesting that their own findings help clarify how phytoplankton species are able to compete with larger organisms
- D.** By recommending that more ecologists focus their research on how competition among phytoplankton species is increased with water density

Question 6 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is A.
- Based on Text 2, it represents how Behrenfeld and colleagues would most likely respond to the “conventional wisdom” discussed in Text 1.
- The conventional wisdom cited holds the opinion that when there is species diversity within a phytoplankton population, “one species should emerge after outcompeting the rest” — that is, after being so successful in competing for resources that the other species vanish from the population.
- However, Text 2 explains that according to Behrenfeld and colleagues, phytoplankton are so small and spaced so far apart in the water that there is “much less” direct competition for resources within phytoplankton populations than scientists had previously thought.

Tip

Write a one-sentence summary of each text's claim first, then name the relationship between them (agree, disagree, qualify, extend) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice B is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: Text 2 never discusses whether routine replenishment of ocean nutrients affects competition between phytoplankton species.

Question 6 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **A**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	By arguing that it is based on a misconception about phytoplankton species competing with one another	Choice A is the best answer because based on Text 2, it represents how Behrenfeld and colleagues would most likely respond to the “conventional wisdom” discussed in Text 1. The conventional wisdom cited holds the opinion that when there is species diversity within a phytoplankton population, “one species should emerge after outcompeting the rest”—that is, after being so successful in competing for resources that the other species vanish from the population. However, Text 2 explains that according to Behrenfeld and colleagues, phytoplankton are so small and spaced so far apart in the water that there is “much less” direct competition for resources within phytoplankton populations than scientists had previously thought.
✗ B	By asserting that it fails to recognize that routine replenishment of ocean nutrients prevents competition between phytoplankton species	Choice B is incorrect because Text 2 never discusses whether routine replenishment of ocean nutrients affects competition between phytoplankton species.
✗ C	By suggesting that their own findings help clarify how phytoplankton species are able to compete with larger organisms	Choice C is incorrect because the interspecies competition discussed in both texts is specifically between phytoplankton species, and neither text considers whether phytoplankton compete for resources with larger nonphytoplankton species.
✗ D	By recommending that more ecologists focus their research on how competition among phytoplankton species is increased with water density	Choice D is incorrect because according to Text 2, Behrenfeld and colleagues argue that water density decreases, not increases, competition between phytoplankton species.

Question 7

Hard

Text 1

Anthropologist Miriam Osei argues that long-distance trade networks in the pre-Columbian Americas were organized primarily around centralized political authorities that controlled the movement of goods.

Text 2

Anthropologist Diego Salas, studying artifact distributions in a different region, argues that trade often persisted through decentralized, kin-based exchange systems that operated independently of, and sometimes despite, political authorities. Salas (Text 2) would most likely respond to Osei's claim in Text 1 by

- A.** agreeing that centralized political authority was necessary for any pre-Columbian trade
- B.** suggesting that Osei's model may not generalize to regions where decentralized exchange predominated
- C.** arguing that trade networks did not exist before European contact
- D.** dismissing artifact distribution as irrelevant evidence for trade patterns

Question 7 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is B.
- Salas's evidence of decentralized, kin-based trade in a different region directly implies skepticism that Osei's centralized-authority model applies universally.

Tip

Write a one-sentence summary of each text's claim first, then name the relationship between them (agree, disagree, qualify, extend) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice A is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: Choice A contradicts Salas's own findings.

Question 7 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: **B**

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
X A	agreeing that centralized political authority was necessary for any pre-Columbian trade	Choice A contradicts Salas's own findings.
✓ B	suggesting that Osei's model may not generalize to regions where decentralized exchange predominated	Choice B is the best answer. Salas's evidence of decentralized, kin-based trade in a different region directly implies skepticism that Osei's centralized-authority model applies universally.
X C	arguing that trade networks did not exist before European contact	Choice C is not supported by either text, both of which assume pre-Columbian trade existed.
X D	dismissing artifact distribution as irrelevant evidence for trade patterns	Choice D contradicts the fact that Salas's own argument relies on artifact distributions.

Question 8

Easy

Text 1

Education researcher Claire Dupont found that students who took practice tests before an exam scored higher than students who only reviewed notes.

Text 2

Education researcher Victor Lindgren found the same practice-testing benefit, but only for material that students had already studied at least once.

How does the finding in Text 2 relate to the finding in Text 1?

- A.** It suggests a condition under which the benefit Dupont observed may or may not occur.
- B.** It shows that practice testing has no benefit at all.
- C.** It contradicts Dupont's finding about reviewing notes.
- D.** It proves that practice testing works regardless of prior study.

Question 8 — Explanation

Explanation

- The correct answer is A.
- Lindgren's finding that the benefit depended on prior study adds a condition to Dupont's original finding rather than negating it.

Tip

Write a one-sentence summary of each text's claim first, then name the relationship between them (agree, disagree, qualify, extend) before reading the choices.

Trap

Choice B is the one most likely to catch a fast reader: Lindgren still found a benefit under certain conditions.

Question 8 — Process of Elimination

Correct answer: A

	Answer choice	Why it is right / wrong
✓ A	It suggests a condition under which the benefit Dupont observed may or may not occur.	Choice A is the best answer. Lindgren's finding that the benefit depended on prior study adds a condition to Dupont's original finding rather than negating it.
✗ B	It shows that practice testing has no benefit at all.	Choice B is incorrect because Lindgren still found a benefit under certain conditions.
✗ C	It contradicts Dupont's finding about reviewing notes.	Choice C is incorrect because neither text directly addresses reviewing notes as a separate claim.
✗ D	It proves that practice testing works regardless of prior study.	Choice D overstates Lindgren's finding, which specifies a condition rather than showing the benefit is unconditional.

Quick Review — Cross-Text Connections

At a Glance

Tests the intellectual relationship between two texts. Your #1 move: write one-sentence summaries of each text first.

Common words: *1 question/test*

Top Rules — Never Forget

- Read each text fully before comparing.
- One-sentence summary of each = your answer.
- Name the relationship type before reading choices.
- Check direction: Text 2 responding to Text 1 $\neq$ Text 1 responding to Text 2.
- Reject answers that overstate the relationship.
- Wrong answers mix up which author said what

Well done.

Craft and Structure: theory and worked questions complete.